

Optimization Checklists

Practical, literal checklists for picking a build configuration and verifying the result. These are the human-facing version of the three settings-group axes from `docs/settings-config-strategy.md` (package aggressiveness, account mode, hardware compatibility) plus the other parameters you actually have to decide on every build. Print this one (see `docs/pdf/`) and tick through it while running a build.

1. Package-aggressiveness profile

- ☐ Is this image for yourself/personal use, where you'd rather uninstall something later than be missing it? → **Normal** (`config/examples/profiles/packages.normal.ps1` — removes only unambiguous OEM/Xbox/gaming bloat, keeps Mail/Calendar/Maps/Camera/Sticky Notes/ToDo/Copilot/Teams/Outlook)
- ☐ Is this today's actual default behavior what you want (a solid debloat, nothing experimental)? → **Reduced** (`packages.reduced.ps1` — matches `asl-win11maker.ps1` 's out-of-the-box `$appPackagePrefixes`, 49 prefixes)
- ☐ Do you want the most stripped-down consumer image possible, including today's commented-out AI/ Recall-era/Photos/Widgets removals? → **Minimal** (`packages.minimal.ps1`)
- ☐ Will this image join Entra ID / be enrolled via Autopilot or Intune, and does it need Teams/Outlook/ OneDrive/Copilot kept for that workflow? → **Corporate** (`packages.corporate.ps1` , equivalent to today's `-KeepCorporateApps`) — remember this also means **Online** account mode below, not Local
- ☐ If none of the four quite fit: pick the closest profile, then hand-add/remove individual prefixes — every item is a single array entry, see `docs/tweak-catalog.md` §1 for what each one is

2. Account mode

- ☐ Is this a disposable/dev/VM/test image that only you (or people you trust with shell access) will ever log into? → **Local** (`-LocalAccountName <name>`) — but first:
 - ☐ Confirmed this image will **never** be reachable by an untrusted network or user — the account password equals the account name in plaintext (`CLAUDE.md` 's documented trade-off)
 - ☐ Aware that `C:\Windows\Panther\unattend.xml` on the installed system will contain that plaintext password (and your product key, if `-ProductKey` was given) with no automatic cleanup today — see `docs/answer-file-generators-options.md` 's sensitive-file finding. Until a cleanup step is added, manually wipe `C:\Windows\Panther\` after first boot if this matters for your use case.
- ☐ Is this image meant for Microsoft/Entra account sign-in, Autopilot, or Intune enrollment? → **Online** (default behavior, or `-KeepCorporateApps` if you also want corporate apps kept)
- ☐ Don't pass `-LocalAccountName` to a `-KeepCorporateApps` build — it's silently ignored with a warning (`CLAUDE.md`), so set your expectations before the build, not after

3. Hardware-compatibility strategy

- ☐ Is the target hardware fully TPM 2.0 / Secure Boot / RAM compliant (or you don't know the target and want to keep Setup's own checks as a safety net)? → **StrictCompliant** (`-BypassMode None` , the default — and the only option `asl-win11-multibuild.ps1` 's **Standard** profile allows)
- ☐ Is the target hardware/VM known to fail one of Setup's checks, but has an ordinary storage controller Setup already sees fine? → **BypassOffline** (`-BypassMode Hive` or `Both` , no driver injection)
- ☐ Does the target have an unusual storage controller (RAID/RST, NVMe RAID, a VM's virtio disk) that Setup can't see without help? → **BypassAndDrivers** (`-BypassMode Both` + `-InjectSystemDrivers` / `-DriverPath` / `-InjectVirtioDrivers` as appropriate) — but first:
 - ☐ Read `docs/build-options-reference.md` 's "Known risk, not yet remediated" note on the storage-driver INF heuristic (winutil `abcbc23`) before trusting this for an uncommon controller — test boot on real/representative hardware, don't assume success from a clean build log alone
 - ☐ Building for a fleet with mixed/unknown hardware? Consider `asl-win11-multibuild.ps1` to produce Standard + your bypass variant in one pass instead of guessing once

4. Pre-build checklist (today's actual parameters)

- ☐ `-Edition <name>` or `-INDEX <n>` decided? (omitting both prompts interactively — fine for a one-off, inconvenient for a repeatable/scripted build)
- ☐ `-CompressionMode` decided — `Fast` (default) for iteration, `Max` for a final distributable image, `None` for the fastest possible local rebuild while testing other changes
- ☐ `-UseSourceCache` passed if you expect to rerun this build multiple times while tuning tweaks/drivers — avoids re-extracting the ISO and re-converting install.esd every run
- ☐ Driver source decided and reachable: host export (`-InjectSystemDrivers`), a specific folder (`-DriverPath`), and/or virtio (`-InjectVirtioDrivers` , with `-VirtioIso` if you don't want the auto-download/auto-detect-cache behavior)
- ☐ Product key decided: a real `-ProductKey` for silent activation, or accept the GVLK/placeholder fallback (`CLAUDE.md` 's precedence chain) — remember `Home/ Core / CoreSingleLanguage` has no GVLK and always falls through to the placeholder-key-with-one-click-through path
- ☐ `-ProfileName` set if this output will share an `output\` folder with other build variants

5. Post-build verification checklist

- ☐ Boot the ISO (VM or real hardware matching your hardware-compatibility choice above) all the way through OOBE without manual intervention beyond what you expected (account creation, product key screen if using the placeholder-key fallback)
- ☐ Confirm the account-mode outcome matches what you picked: local admin account created vs. Microsoft/ Entra sign-in offered
- ☐ Confirm expected apps are actually gone / actually present, spot-checking a few from your chosen package profile (Start menu search is enough for a quick check)

- ☐ For a **serviceable** (non- `-Core`) build: check Windows Update at least once (`Settings > Windows Update > Check for updates`) to confirm the image can still take updates — this is the whole point of not using `-Core`
- ☐ For a `-Core` build: confirm you're treating it as disposable/non-serviceable per its own warning — don't try to add features/languages or rely on Windows Recovery afterward
- ☐ If drivers were injected for an unusual storage controller: confirm the disk was actually visible to Setup during install (not just that the build completed without error) — see the known-risk note in checklist §3 above

See also

- `docs/settings-config-strategy.md` — the config-file system these checklists are the human-readable front end for.
- `docs/build-options-reference.md` — full detail behind every checklist item above.